For a people who bring a shine to others' lives, their own are filled with darkness. The diamond polishers of Gujarat, numbering an estimated 800,000, are finding themselves out of a livelihood that has been handed down to them over generations and which is the only vocation that they have ever known. According to industry insiders, some 15,000 people have lost their jobs in recent months. Unable to cope with the uncertainty, many of them are taking their own lives. Among them was 55-year-old Vinu Moradiya from Surat, who had lost his job this year, making it difficult for him to support his family of six. Driven by despair, he, his wife and their two younger children entered a pact and died by suicide in early June, leaving behind 25-year-old Rushita and her 22-year-old brother Parth. Heartbroken, Rushita, too, tried to take her own life three days later, but, thankfully, survived.

India may have exhausted its diamond mines long ago, but it has emerged as a world leader in the supply of cut and polished diamonds, thanks mostly to the business prowess of the diamantaires of Gujarat. Having imported roughs worth over Rs 1.4 lakh crore in FY23, the country's exports of finished diamonds touched nearly Rs 2 lakh crore during the fiscal, or about 20 per cent of the world's total. However, hit first by the Covid-19 pandemic and then the Ukraine-Russia war that curtailed the supply of rough diamonds to India, besides the cheaper lab-grown diamonds from China that have flooded the global markets, the business has been seeing a steady downturn. In the first quarter of this financial year (FY24), exports stood at about Rs 37,000 crore, a steep 24 per cent year-over-year (YoY) decline from Rs 48,350 crore in Q1FY23. The changed market dynamics have had the worst impact on those at the bottom of the pyramid—the diamond polishers and other small traders.

Surat, which alone employs 90 per cent of the state's diamond cutters and polishers in some 4,000 firms (with another 4,000 straddling Ahmedabad, Borsad and the small towns and villages of the Bhavnagar and Amreli districts in Saurashtra), has recorded at least 22 suicides since May this year—attributed to job loss and financial distress stemming from the upheaval in the industry. Besides Moradiya and his three family members, 25-year-old Jenish Gujarati, also a diamond polisher, is part of the unfortunate statistic. On June 7, he jumped into the Tapi river to escape the burden of joblessness and poverty.

Others, like 40-year-old Bharat Kamaniya, meanwhile, are trying to cope. Hailing from Mahuva in Bhavnagar, Kamaniya was forced to migrate to Surat with his farm labourer parents in 1994 because of the lack of water for irrigation in parched Saurashtra. Starting at the young age of 15, Kamaniya has since worked with multiple medium-sized diamond polishing firms. But in May, he was laid off by the firm where he had been for the past two years. Now, he has been taking up odd jobs that earn him Rs 300-400 per day—less than half the Rs 25,000 monthly salary he used to draw. However, unlike his peers, Kamaniya does not want to return to Mahuva. "We are not landowners. I will end up working as a farm labourer or be forced to take up a low-paying job at a small diamond polishing unit there. My two children are studying here in good schools, thanks to the Right to Education quota. I want them to become smart, city-bred kids," he says, clinging on to some optimism even as anxiety is writ large on his face.

Sitting in a tiny air-conditioned office in Surat's Varachha Road area, Bhavesh Tank, vice-president of the 30,000-strong Gujarat Diamond Workers' Union, claims that he receives at least 10 representations in a day from unemployed diamond polishers seeking help in

IN THE ROUGH
Small diamond traders at work in Surat



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

8,000
Diamond polishing units in Gujarat, half of them in Surat, employing 90 per cent of the workforce

15,000
Estimated number of the 800,000-odd diamond cutters and polishers laid off across Gujarat